According to an Ipsos/Steria poll published on January 21, 2014 by *Le Monde*, 8% of the French—only 8%!—trusted the political parties. Only 23% trusted their National Assembly representatives. Trade unions, at just 31%, fared little better; nor did the judiciary, at 46%. Real confidence was shown only with local government: 63% of the French trusted their mayors. Most trusted were the police and the army, with respectively a 73% and a 79% confidence rate (a recipe for a coup d'état, one might say.)[4]

Defiance against traditional politics translate into electoral returns. The abstention rate was 40% at the French local elections in March 2014, and almost 60% at the Euro-Parliament elections in May 2014. In both cases, it boosted Marine Le Pen's National Front, originally a far right party, but now a more global protest party with both rightwing and leftwing characters.

France's current government, the Fifth Republic established by Charles de Gaulle in 1958, was long perceived as a stable and efficient democracy, although that was largely a fallacy. From the very onset, the Fifth Republic was subverted by the "Noblesse d'État (State nobility) to use a term coined by sociologist Pierre Bourdieu: the senior civil service, which supplanted the political class and merged with the economic elite. About 70% of all members of government and parliament are civil servants. A further blow came from the European Union Commission in Brussels, a non-elected multi-national super-government that gradually superseded the elected national government of France on many issues, including money supply and day to day legislation. Finally, there was the immigration factor: the ever-growing non-Western immigrant communities who more often than not tended to ignore French traditional culture and values—including in political matters—and to enforce their own.

As long as the economy was booming, welfare benefits increasing, and the legal working hours shrinking (it went down to 35 hours per week with five weeks' vacation, plus eight legal holidays easily turned into extended weekends), most citizens did not pay attention. Things changed when the French economy was no longer able to deliver. In 2005, an angry France derailed the so-called European constitutional treaty in a referendum. In 2007, it elected the conservative Nicolas Sarkozy on the assumption that he would curb the state nobility, tame immigration, lower taxes, and revive the domestic economy. Sarkozy took some steps, but at the end of the day disappointed his constituency on almost all counts. In 2012, the pendulum swung to the socialist François Hollande, who promised lots of things to his own supporters but eventually had to admit that he could not deliver, and is currently seen as a pathetic figure. No wonder that radical parties (from the National Front to the Greens and the neocommunist Left Front) are

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